Tourette's Syndrome

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Symptoms

- Involuntary movements like blinking, shrugging or head jerking (motor tics).
- Involuntary sounds like grunting, throat clearing or words (vocal tics).
- An uncomfortable physical urge or sensation before the tic happens.

Age & Gender

- Symptoms usually appear between ages 5 and 9.
- Males account for 75% to 80% of diagnoses.

Common myths

- Most people do not swear (coprolalia affects only about 10% of cases).
- Tics are not done for attention or bad behaviour.
- People cannot simply stop their tics.

Diagnosis

- Diagnosed when a person has multiple motor tics and at least one vocal tic.
- Symptoms must have lasted for more than a year.

Professional support

- Comprehensive Behavioural Intervention for Tics teaches strategies to manage tic urges.
- Medication may be used if tics cause pain, injury, or severe distress.
- Support groups help reduce stigma and improve self-esteem.

How to help

- Ignore the tics completely. Do not stare, laugh, or comment.
- Do not tell them to stop or ask them to be quiet.
- Help reduce stress, as strong emotions can increase tics.

This information isn't a diagnostic tool. If you recognise these symptoms in yourself or others, please contact a doctor.

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